



Welder

welder • 6-7 mo cert program or 3-4 yr union apprenticeship

\$45K-\$70K / yr

THE TRADE

Join metal with precision across construction, fabrication, and repair. Welding is the speed record among trades — a community-college certificate ending in an AWS certification can put you in a paying job in about 6-7 months, and specialized pipe welders (6G) regularly clear \$80K-\$110K.

SALARY & TRAINING

JOURNEYMAN BAND (SITE FIGURE — SAME AS QUIZ RESULT & TRADES PAGE)

\$45K-\$70K

BLS median ~\$47,000 (blog-cited) • cert-to-hire in ~6-7 mo (AWS D1.1) or 3-4 yr union path • 6G pipe welders: \$80K-\$110K+

THE PATH: FROM RESEARCH TO HIRED

01 RESEARCH Compare training routes, union vs non-union, and local demand

02 TRAIN Trade school / pre-apprenticeship — start with OSHA 10

03 HANDS-ON Apprentice years: log hours, earn raises to 80-90% of scale

04 CERTIFIED Pass the journeyman or industry certification exam

05 HIRED Journey-level pay — specialize, stack certs, own the shop

Every apprentice track pays from day one — typical start is 40-50% of journey scale with scheduled raises every year. Each step above is fully mapped on the TradeLift Getting Started guide and the site's resources page.



Welder — Roadmap, page 2

CERTIFICATIONS + FIRST 12 WEEKS

REQUIRED CERTIFICATIONS & CREDENTIALS

AWS D1.1 (structural steel) — the entry-level credential

YOUR FIRST 12 WEEKS — THE ACTION CHECKLIST

- ☐ Take the TradeLift quiz to confirm fit
- ☐ Research local program costs (\$0-\$15k)
- ☐ Earn OSHA 10 + welding-safety basics
- ☐ Visit a community college welding lab
- ☐ Buy a hood, gloves, chipping hammer
- ☐ Practice basic bead runs on scrap
- ☐ Compare school vs union timelines
- ☐ Apply to 2-3 school programs
- ☐ Meet one AWS-certified welder in person
- ☐ Test stick and MIG without stopping
- ☐ Apply to 2 union apprenticeships
- ☐ Land your first cert, then stack more

Full career steps, certifications, and tool guides: <https://tradelift.surge.sh/getting-started.html>